

Frontend Deployment on Netlify (Drag & Drop dist Folder)

Overview

This document explains **frontend deployment on Netlify** using the **manual drag & drop method** after completing **database and backend deployment**.

This approach is commonly used for:

- Internship projects
 - College / CDAC projects
 - Demo applications
 - Quick production testing
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Deployment Flow (Recommended Order)

1. Database Deployment ☒
 2. Backend Deployment on Railway ☒
 3. Update Frontend Service Layer with Deployed Backend URL ☒
 4. Build Frontend Application (**dist** folder) ☒
 5. Deploy Frontend on Netlify (Drag & Drop) ☒
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Step 1: Prerequisites

Before starting frontend deployment, ensure:

- Backend is successfully deployed on **Railway**
 - Backend APIs are accessible via deployed URL
 - Frontend application is running correctly in local environment
 - You are using **React** or **React + Vite**
 - You have a **Netlify account**
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Step 2: Update Backend URL in Frontend (Very Important)

After backend deployment on Railway, replace **local backend URL** with **deployed backend URL** in the frontend service layer.

Example: Service Layer Change

✗ Local URL (Before Deployment)

```
const BASE_URL = "http://localhost:3000";
```

☑ Deployed URL (After Railway Deployment)

```
const BASE_URL = "https://your-backend-name.up.railway.app";
```

🔗 This change ensures the frontend communicates with the deployed backend instead of localhost.

Step 3: Build the Frontend Project

For Vite Projects

Run the following command:

```
npm run build
```

➡ This command generates a **dist/ folder**, which contains the **production-ready frontend build**.

Output Folder Structure

```
project-folder
├── dist
├── src
├── package.json
└── vite.config.js
```

⚠ Important Rules

- ✗ Do NOT upload **src** folder
- ✗ Do NOT upload zip file
- ☑ Upload ONLY the **dist** folder

Step 4: Login to Netlify

1. Open the Netlify website
2. Login using one of the following:
 - GitHub
 - Google
 - Email

After login, you will be redirected to the **Netlify Dashboard**.

Step 5: Deploy Using Drag & Drop (Manual Deployment)

1. From Netlify Dashboard, click **Add new site**
2. Select **Deploy manually**
3. Drag and drop the **dist** folder into the upload area
4. Wait for deployment (usually **10–30 seconds**)

 **Frontend deployment completed successfully!**

Step 6: Get Live Website URL

After deployment, Netlify automatically provides a live URL:

```
https://random-name.netlify.app
```

You can also:

- Rename the site
 - Add a custom domain
 - Enable HTTPS (auto-enabled by Netlify)
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Step 7: Fix 404 Error on Page Refresh (React Router Issue)

If your application uses **react-router-dom**, refreshing a page may show a **404 error**.

Solution: Add **_redirects** File

1. Inside the **public** folder, create a file named:

```
_redirects
```

2. Add the following content:

```
/*      /index.html    200
```

3. Rebuild the project:

```
npm run build
```

4. Re-upload the updated **dist** folder to Netlify

Common Errors & Fixes

Issue	Cause	Solution
Blank Page	Wrong API URL	Update service layer URL
API not working	Backend not deployed	Check Railway backend
404 on refresh	Missing redirects	Add _redirects file
Site not loading	Uploaded wrong folder	Upload dist only

When to Use Drag & Drop Deployment

☒ Best For

- Student projects
- Internship demos
- One-time deployment
- Testing production build

☐ Not Recommended For

- Frequent updates
 - Team collaboration
 - CI/CD workflows
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